What does 'better' actually mean?

Turn a vague judgment into a clear rule that another person can apply.

Suggested teaching time: 30 min | Preparation: about 5 min

Introductory | Secondary and adult learners | Individual writing, pairs, and class discussion

Prerequisites: None; learners compare simple counts and averages without doing arithmetic.

Students will be able to

- Identify an ambiguous term that affects a judgment.
- Define the term with a measure, direction, group, and comparison period.
- Apply two definitions to the same facts and explain why they yield different judgments.

Prepare and gather

- One student handout per learner, or display the activities and use paper.
- Pens or pencils; no calculator or student device required.
- Instructor guide with model answers, kept separate from the handout.
- Read the scenarios and note that every before-and-after comparison uses the same stated group.
- Print the three-page handout or display each activity in turn.
- Explain that all figures are invented for practice, and that observing a change does not show what caused it.

Teaching sequence

5 min	**Spot the ambiguous word.** Learners complete the warm-up and compare answers. Explain that a useful definition says what is measured, what change counts as improvement, and which group and periods are compared.
10 min	**Apply two definitions.** Pairs complete the phone-rule activity. Ask them to write definitions before stating whether either measure improves. Circulate and check that both periods and the same classes are named.
8 min	**Discuss the choice of measure.** Reveal and discuss the main model answer. Use both discussion prompts. Emphasize that a purpose should guide the choice of measure and that these figures do not isolate the rule's causal effect.
7 min	**Transfer the skill.** Learners complete the bus-service exit ticket independently. Use the criteria to check their two definitions and conclusions, then discuss the model answer.

Timings are suggested starting points, not measured classroom completion times.

Warm-up / A more successful reading club

Student task and instructor answer

Explain these words as needed

Ambiguous term: A word or phrase with more than one reasonable meaning in its context.

Measure: An observable quantity used to judge a particular feature, such as weekly interruptions or average test scores.

Comparison period: The times being compared, such as the four weeks before and after a rule.

Scenario

Invented scenario: A club leader says, 'Our reading club became more successful this month.' Average attendance per meeting rose from 12 last month to 18 this month, but the average number of books finished per member stayed at one per month.

Student output: Write one ambiguous phrase, two possible meanings, and the result under each meaning.

1. Identify the phrase that needs a clearer meaning.

2. Give one meaning using attendance and one using books finished per member.

3. State whether each meaning shows improvement in this month compared with last month.

Student success check: Do your two meanings refer to different outcomes, and does each conclusion match the figures?

Model answer

'More successful' needs clarification. If it means higher average attendance per meeting this month than last month, there is improvement from 12 to 18. If it means more books finished per member per month, there is no improvement: the average remains one.

Why this meets the task: The answer makes two plausible interpretations explicit and applies the supplied values. It does not assume that attendance and reading volume are interchangeable.

Main activity / Does the phone rule make lessons better?

Student task and instructor answer

Scenario

Invented scenario: A principal says a new phone rule makes lessons 'better'. In the same ten classes, weekly phone interruptions fell from 20 to 12, but average test scores stayed at 70 out of 100. Both figures compare the four weeks before the rule with the four weeks after it.

Student output: Write two definitions, two conclusions applying those definitions, and one sentence explaining how to choose a measure.

1. Write two possible definitions of 'better': one using interruptions and one using test scores. For each, state the direction of improvement, the group, and the comparison period.
2. Apply each definition to the supplied figures and say whether it shows an improvement.
3. Finish with one sentence explaining why the school's purpose should guide its choice of measure before results are inspected.

Student success check: Could a reader apply your two rules to the figures without guessing? Separate observing a change from claiming the rule caused it.

Model answer

Definition 1: fewer weekly phone interruptions across these ten classes in the four weeks after the rule than before it. This measure improves from 20 to 12. Definition 2: a higher average test score in the same classes and periods. This measure shows no improvement: 70 in both periods. The school should choose according to whether its purpose is reducing disruption or improving test performance, rather than picking whichever result looks best.

Why this meets the task: Both definitions specify an observable measure, direction, group, and comparison. The conclusions follow from those definitions. The answer does not claim that the rule caused the observed reduction in interruptions.

Exit ticket / A better bus service?

Student task and instructor answer

Scenario

Invented scenario: A town calls its revised bus service 'better'. On the same route, average passenger waiting time fell from 12 minutes in the month before the revision to 8 minutes in the month after it. The fare per journey rose from $2 to $3 over the same comparison. No other outcomes are supplied.

Student output: Write two clear definitions of 'better', apply each to the figures, and write one sentence about choosing between them.

1. Define 'better' using waiting time, naming the direction of improvement, route, and periods.
2. Define 'better' using fare per journey, again naming the direction of improvement and comparison.
3. State what each definition shows and why the town should identify its priority before selecting a definition.

Student success check: Have you distinguished an improvement in waiting time from a worsening in affordability, without claiming either captures every aspect of the service?

Model answer

Using time: better means a lower average waiting time on this route in the month after the revision than before it. This improves from 12 to 8 minutes. Using cost: better means a lower fare per journey on the same route over those periods. This worsens because the fare rises from $2 to $3. The town should state whether it prioritizes shorter waits, lower fares, or an explicit balance before choosing its standard.

Why this meets the task: Both rules can be applied without guessing. They lead to different judgments about different features, so an overall verdict requires a stated priority or tradeoff rather than silently changing the definition.

Check understanding

Mark each criterion met or needs another attempt. Accept equivalent wording; assess the reasoning, not a memorized phrase.

- Each definition names a measure, direction, group, and comparison period.
- The conclusions correctly apply the supplied figures to those definitions.
- The explanation links the choice of measure to an aim and avoids claiming that the figures prove causation.

Discussion and adaptations

Use the supplied guidance to keep the lesson focused on its reasoning skill.

Discussion prompts

Are both definitions of 'better lessons' legitimate?

Listen for: Both can measure relevant educational aims, but neither captures every aim. A definition must fit the purpose; usefulness does not follow merely from being easy to count.

Why choose the measure before looking at the result?

Listen for: Choosing only a favorable outcome afterward can conceal disappointing results. Stating the aim and measure first makes the evaluation more transparent.

Common confusions

A precise definition is automatically the right definition. A rule can be precise yet poorly matched to the purpose. Ask what the activity is supposed to achieve.

One improving measure proves the whole policy is successful. State exactly which feature improved and consider other relevant aims before giving an overall verdict.

A before-and-after difference proves the rule caused it. These exercises identify what changed under a definition. Other changes could explain the difference; no causal comparison is supplied.

Adapt the lesson

More support: Use the sentence frame: 'Better means [higher/lower] [measure] for [group] in [later period] compared with [earlier period].' Let pairs explain their definitions orally before writing.

More challenge: Ask learners to describe an aim that the two phone-rule measures miss, such as student well-being, and a possible way to measure it. Accept it as a proposed measure; no conclusion about its result is justified without data.

Next practice

https://xixteen.com/learners/?practice=define_terms#workbench

Define Your Terms Before You Draw Conclusions: https://xixteen.com/articles/ai-advice-and-your-judgment/